

Curriculum Design Document

**Portfolio piece: This is a fictional project created to demonstrate the instructional design process. Not affiliated with any real organisation, employer, or client.*

Title:	Interactivity Level:
Foundations of Supportive Counseling	L3
Instructional Designer:	Duration:
Francis Cheng Ter Yuen	15 Minutes

Section 1: Purpose

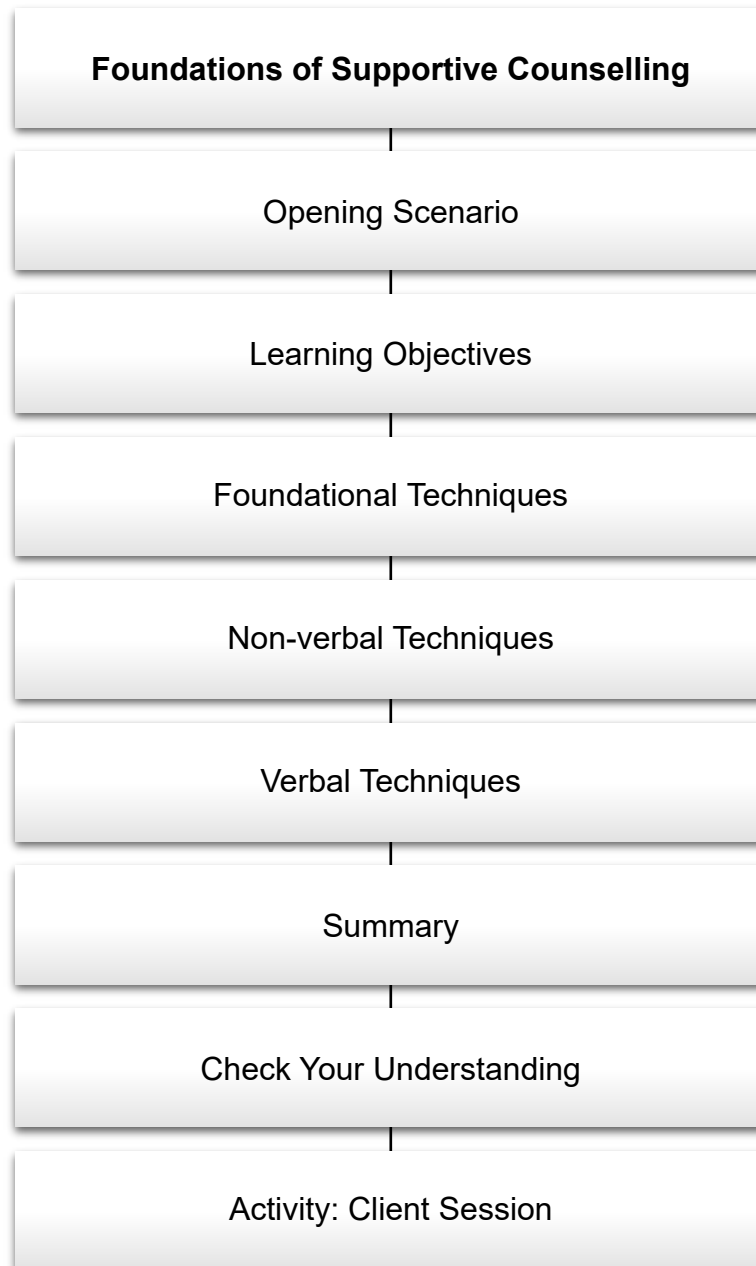
The purpose of this course is to equip learners, such as trainee counsellors or new helping professionals, with foundational verbal and non-verbal communication techniques used in supportive counselling conversations. Learners will understand core listening and response techniques, then apply them in a simulated, branching client session.

Section 2: Instructional Strategy

Merrill's First Principles of Instructional Design	
Merrill's Principles of Instruction were founded by M. David Merrill, a noted educational researcher and teacher. There are five core principles centred on task-based learning: Problem, Activation, Demonstration, Application, and Integration. He suggests that truly effective learning experiences are rooted in problem-solving — learning is facilitated when learners are engaged in solving real-world problems.	
Problem	Engage learners in solving real-world problems
Strategies	Present learners with an opening scenario involving a real-world case. State learning objectives up front.
Activation	Activate learners' relevant prior experience
Strategies	Use questioning to activate recall of everyday communication experience.
Demonstration	Demonstrate the new knowledge to learners
Strategies	Provide worked examples of each technique. Use text, illustration, and dialogue snippets to cater to different learning styles.
Application	Provide opportunities for learners to apply new knowledge
Strategies	Incorporate Check Your Understanding questions. Provide feedback addressing misconceptions.
Integration	Encourage learners to integrate new knowledge into practice

Strategies	Provide a summary of key points. Invite learners to reflect on their session choices.
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Section 3: Proposed Content Flow for Course



Section 4: Lesson Coverage

Opening Scenario

Line 1: Have you ever had a moment where you could tell someone didn't quite mean what they said?

Scene: Text fades/wipes in on entrance. Beside it, two simple speech bubble icons, one neutral, one with a slightly furrowed brow, to visually hint at mismatched communication.

Line 2: In such cases, you are picking up on subtle cues that helps you see whether someone may not be fully honest.

Scene: Transition to a simple two-person icon layout (counsellor and client, using generic silhouette or content library figures, side by side or facing each other, seated). A small speech bubble with neutral text fades in above the client figure. A second, smaller icon, a wavy "emotion" or heart icon in a muted colour, fades in slightly below or beside it, to represent the unspoken feeling underneath the words.

Line 3: As a counsellor, this applies to not only your client's behaviours but your own words and actions as well.

Scene: The two-person icon layout fades to lower opacity as the text takes visual priority. The phrase "core skill" appears.

Line 4 (closing question): Why is self-awareness of our own behaviours essential in counselling and what are the different techniques we can apply to help clients feel truly heard?

Scene: Background elements recede further (fade to low opacity). The question text fades in.

Learning Outcomes

In this module, you will learn to:

- Recognise the importance of foundational verbal and non-verbal techniques in supportive conversations
- Identify core verbal and non-verbal techniques used in supportive conversations
- Apply active listening, open-ended questions, paraphrasing, and reflecting feelings in a simulated session

Foundational Techniques

- Within counselling, clients will pay very close attention to your words, their tone and your behaviour
- Clients often have a stronger belief in expressions and tone over words spoken
- Incongruence between your words and expression can lead to loss of trust

Non-verbal Techniques

- The importance of non-verbals?
 - Non-verbals include the emotions and unspoken messages
 - Create trust and transparency in relationships (Non-verbal signals matching words)

- Non-verbal responses show understanding and care
- Importance of Listening
 - Poor listening is often the cause of misunderstandings and resulting conflict
 - Having the feeling of being truly heard is important to people
 - To increase the effectiveness of listening, people need to listen completely, without leaping to conclusions or thinking about what to say next
 - Obstacles to Active Listening
 - Ordering, warning, or threatening
 - Giving advice or providing solutions too early
 - Moralising or telling people what they "should" do
 - Judging, criticising, or blaming
 - Withdrawing or changing the subject
- Eye contact
 - Signals interest in others
 - People who make eye contact convey interest, concern, warmth and credibility

Verbal Techniques

- Open-Ended Questions
 - Purpose is to collect information while reducing the feeling of being interrogated
 - Begin questions with what, when, who, where, or how — never why, which can feel accusatory
- Paraphrasing (Reflecting Content)
 - Purpose is to clarify content, check perceptions, and provide feedback
 - Summarise in a concise form: "So, what I hear you saying is..."
- Reflecting Feelings & Validation
 - Reflecting feelings responds to the emotional status of the individual, not just the content
 - Validation builds trust by giving the person the right to have their emotions, without needing to justify them
- Clarifying & Summarising
 - Clarifying focuses on specific content to be clearer about the direction of the conversation
 - Summarising logically pieces together what has been discussed, to put things into perspective

Check Your Understanding

1. Which of the following is an example of an open-ended question?
 - "Why did you leave your last job?"
 - "You're feeling okay about this, right?"
 - "What has this past week been like for you?" ✓ (correct)
 - "Did that upset you?"

Feedback

Open-ended questions use words like what, when, who, where, or how, and invite the person to share more in their own words, rather than steering them toward a yes/no or a specific answer.

2. Match the different examples to their corresponding verbal skill that a counsellor can use.

Verbal Skill	Example
Paraphrasing	"So what I'm hearing is, the deadline pressure has really been building up for you."
Reflecting Feelings	"It sounds like you're feeling overwhelmed right now."
Validation	"It's okay to feel this way, especially given everything going on."
Summarising	"So we've talked about the workload, the deadline, and how it's been affecting your sleep."

Feedback (Correct)

That's correct!

Feedback (Incorrect 2nd try)

That's incorrect. Here are the correct answers. [Correct answers will be shown]

Activity: Simulated Client Session

Learners engage in a branching conversation with Wei Jie, a client processing stress following a recent career change. Each decision point offers a choice between applying a technique well and a common misstep, with the conversation branching toward a constructive or unproductive outcome depending on learner choices.

For full branching structure, refer to the accompanying document:

Foundations_of_Supportive_Counselling_Branching.pdf

Summary

Foundational Techniques
• Within counselling, clients will pay very close attention to your words, their tone and your body language • Stronger belief in expressions and tone over words spoken • Incongruence between your words and expression can lead to loss of trust
Non-verbal Techniques
• Importance of Listening ○ Poor listening is often the cause of misunderstandings and resulting conflict ○ Obstacles to Active Listening ▪ Ordering, warning, or threatening ▪ Giving advice or providing solutions too early ▪ Moralising or telling people what they "should" do ▪ Judging, criticising, or blaming ▪ Withdrawing or changing the subject • Eye contact ○ Signals interest in others
Verbal Techniques
• Open-Ended Questions • Paraphrasing (Reflecting Content) • Reflecting Feelings & Validation • Clarifying & Summarising

Activity: Simulated Client Session

For full branching design, please refer to the accompanying document "Foundations_of_Supportive_Counselling_Branching.pdf"

Section 5: Navigation of Courseware

Option 1: Free Navigation

Option 2: Restricted Navigation

Option 3: Lock Navigation (selected)

Section 6: Completion Status Setting

Option 1: Course Completion (selected)

Option 2: Quiz Result

Section 7: List of Resources

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